

Day 2 — Working Backwards

Activity packet for participant triads. Day 2 produces a one-page PR/FAQ per triad and runs the first cross-triad critique of the academy.

Prerequisite artifacts (from Day 1)

- Triad **Prompt Pattern Library** (at minimum: Research, Summarization, Critique-hat, Where-could-you-be-wrong)
- Day 3 research target question per triad
- Optional: a chosen product idea per triad (from the FieldPulse backlog list below)

FieldPulse backlog — eligible product ideas

Pick any one per triad. Triads may also propose their own subject to facilitator approval.

1. **End-of-Day Reconcile** — guided flow for dispatchers to close out the day in 5 min
2. **Mid-Day Re-Route** — AI-assisted tech re-routing when someone calls out sick
3. **Tech-First Messaging** — replace dispatcher-tech phone/text with in-app async
4. **Offline Ticket Capture** — tech mobile app works on zero connectivity, syncs on reconnect
5. **Inventory True-Up** — automatically reconciles truck stock vs. parts used per job
6. **Customer Follow-Up** — post-visit check-in that routes dissatisfaction to a dispatcher
7. **Tech Onboarding Fast Lane** — 20-min-or-less onboarding for a new hire

Activity 1 — Forward or Backward?

Format: Triad • 30 min • Block 1

Purpose

Before drafting, calibrate what the difference feels like in practice by analyzing 4 short vignettes.

Setup

Your triad has the four vignettes below (also available as the handout `week-01/handouts/working-backwards-vignettes.md`). Have a way to take quick notes — paper or shared doc is fine.

Steps

1. **Read (10 min).** Each triad member reads all four vignettes silently.
2. **Sort (5 min).** Tag each vignette: forward, backward, or ambiguous.
3. **Discuss (10 min).** For each: what's the one question that, if asked earlier, would have changed the outcome?
4. **Full-room debrief (5 min).** Cohort-wide discussion of vignettes C and D.

Vignettes

1. **Vignette A** — A dispatch-tool founder, after hearing customers complain about mobile app speed, built a native iOS rewrite over two quarters. At launch, 40% of techs still used the web view because they'd switched Android mid-project.
2. **Vignette B** — A PM wrote a one-page mock press release for "OfflineFirst Ticket Capture" and circulated it to five techs for reaction. Three said they'd already built paper workarounds; two said the app's login flow was the real blocker. The PR was re-scoped to login before offline.
3. **Vignette C** — Engineering discovered a faster map-tile rendering library and shipped it as a mid-sprint improvement. Dispatcher satisfaction bumped 12 points in next-survey.
4. **Vignette D** — A PM drafted a PR/FAQ for "Tech-First Messaging" and had AI generate three customer quotes. The quotes all used marketing language no tech would say. The PM skipped persona research and shipped anyway.

Debrief questions (full room, 15 min)

- Which vignettes are clearly forward? Clearly backward?
- C and D are designed to be ambiguous. Why does each matter?
- For each, what's the **one question that, if asked earlier, would have changed the outcome?**

Deliverable

A one-sentence "earlier question" per vignette, recorded by the triad and surfaced in the cohort debrief.

Activity 2 — Headline + Sub-headline

Format: Triad • 45 min • Block 2

Purpose

Produce three candidate headlines, then use AI to critique them on three axes. Pick one.

Setup

Your triad has chosen (or will pick now) one product idea from the backlog above. Confirm AI assistant access.

Steps

1. Pick a product idea from the backlog (or a triad's own)
2. Draft **three** candidate PR heading + sub-headings (5 min per candidate)
3. Use the following prompt (adapted from your Pattern Library):

Role: A skeptical HVAC dispatcher reading the following three product announcement headlines.

Context:

- You have been a dispatcher for 12 years.
- You are cynical about new tools because you've been burned by three migrations.
- You care about: time saved, trust from your shop owner, and not looking stupid in front of techs.

Task: For each of the three, answer:

1. Would I actually click this email?
2. What does this promise that might not deliver?
3. Is this interchangeable with a competitor's marketing?

Format: Markdown table. Be direct.

4. Pick one candidate. Write **two sentences** defending the choice.

Deliverable

The single chosen heading + sub-headline, pinned for use in Activity 3.

Activity 3 — Answer the Five, Concretely

Format: Triad • 45 min • Block 3

Purpose

Complete a draft PR paragraph + customer quote + 6 FAQ entries.

Setup

Your triad has its chosen heading/sub-headline from Activity 2. Use the PR template below.

Steps

1. **Plan (10 min).** Map the heading/sub-heading to the rest of the template; identify the riskiest section.
2. **Draft (25 min).** Fill the template — Summary, Problem, Solution, Customer quote, both FAQs.
3. **Self-review (10 min).** Read aloud within the triad; tag every claim with an evidence tier.

Template

```
# [Heading from Activity 2]

## Sub-headline
[From Activity 2]

## Summary paragraph (3–4 sentences, as-if-launched)
...

## Problem paragraph (2–3 sentences; name the pain specifically)
...

## Solution paragraph (2–3 sentences; mechanism must be explicit)
...

## Customer quote
11 ... — [Name], [Role], [Company]

## Customer FAQ (3 entries)
**Q:** ...
**A:** ...

## Internal FAQ (3 entries)
**Q:** ...
**A:** ...

## Evidence log (every claim gets a tier)
- Claim: ... — Tier: [Observed | Reported | Inferred | AI-generated] — Source: ...
```

Rules

- Every factual claim in Summary/Problem/Solution gets a row in the Evidence log.
- Customer quote must be believably in-character — no marketing speak, no adjective-salad.
- Internal FAQ must include: riskiest assumption, build-estimate-and-evidence, 30%-adoption scenario.

Deliverable

A complete one-page PR/FAQ per triad: heading, sub-headline, three paragraphs, customer quote, 3 customer FAQs, 3 internal FAQs, and an Evidence log.

Activity 4 — Cross-Triad PR/FAQ Review

Format: Paired triads • 60 min • Block 4

Purpose

Two triads exchange PR/FAQs and run the academy's first cross-triad critique. The critique protocol is what makes it productive instead of defensive.

Setup

Pair with another triad. Both triads have a completed PR/FAQ from Activity 3 and a stopwatch (phone is fine).

The critique protocol (enforce)

MINUTES	ACTIVITY
0–2	Silent read. Reviewer marks 1 line they love, 1 they question.
2–5	"What I heard." Reviewer restates the product in one sentence.
5–10	Questions only. Reviewer asks, author listens and takes notes. No defending.
10–15	Author response. Author says what they'll change and what they'll leave (with reason).

Post-critique revision (15 min)

- Revise the PR/FAQ to address the highest-priority concern
- Update the Evidence log for any claim that changed tier

Readout (60 seconds per triad)

"We changed X because the reviewer helped us see Y. We left Z because we disagreed for this reason."

Failure-mode rubric (reviewers use this as their check)

FAILURE	IF PRESENT...
Generic customer	Push the author for role + context + evidence
Category problem	Replace noun with verb; give an example
Benefit bouquet	Make them choose one; defend it
Handwave evidence	Ask for the tier; push for the source
Feature description	Ask them to describe the moment of use, not the tool

Deliverable

A revised PR/FAQ per triad with documented changes (what changed, what was left, and why) plus a 60-second readout.

End-of-day checkpoint

- ✓ Each triad has a completed one-page PR/FAQ + FAQ entries + Evidence log
- ✓ Each triad has been critiqued by one other triad and has documented what they changed/left
- ✓ Each triad has identified their **most worrying unvalidated assumption** (the one that keeps their PR from being fully defensible)

Bridge to Day 3

The PR customer quote is Day 3 persona input. The "most worrying unvalidated assumption" is the first thing to interrogate with the Day 3 validation protocol.